requires it,' says Mukundan. The MD recalls how Ratan pushed for the 'Save the Whale Shark Campaign' in Gujarat.

The whale shark, the largest fish in the world, was sought after along the Gujarat coast for its oil and meat. Its numbers had dwindled, and it was declared an endangered species in 2001. Tata Chemicals took up the project to save it in 2004. The project created awareness amongst fishermen, especially in the Veraval, Sutrapada and Dhamlej region. It became a roaring success and is now in the third phase of implementation. Until 2019, around 700 sharks, which had accidently got trapped in the fishing nets of fishermen, were rescued and released.

Building Transparency

Fighting corruption and building transparency in both corporate dealings and the political realm has been a priority with Ratan. He so determinedly pursued this goal that in many instances, Tata companies faced the opprobrium of politicians and lost out to competition. But he paid the price to uphold the group's ethical values.

While many industrial houses exploited the demand for political funding and used it as leverage to extract favours from the establishment, in an uncommon move, Ratan sought to instead use it as a means to strengthen the democratic process. With this objective in focus, in 1996, he established the Progressive Electoral Trust to make political donations. It was 'something beyond business', recalls Subedar. Ratan's objective was to achieve transparency and accountability in the funding of political parties by corporates. Though not often spoken about, it is his enduring contribution to Indian democracy as his scheme discouraged corruption and crony capitalism and presaged the adoption of a similar one by the government of India. Ratan was 'the chief architect of the fund', but he preferred that it be operated by a 'panel of trustees'. He was in no way 'involved' in its operation.

Dinesh Vyas, a senior advocate, Supreme Court of India, was appointed president of the electoral trust, while D.M. Sukhatankar 'ex-municipal commissioner of Mumbai' and Hansa Mehta, 'a reputed social worker' were the other trustees. The scheme became operational and in the 2004 elections, it financed political parties to the tune of Rs 7 crore.